

TRAGIC HERO

THE POPULAR CINE STAR AND THE FILM INDUSTRY ARE SHOCKED BY THE VERDICT BUT THE JUDGE MAKES IT CLEAR THAT BEING A CELEBRITY HAS NO VALUE WHEN IT COMES TO BREAKING THE LAW. AN ANALYSIS OF DUTT'S LEGAL OPTIONS AND WHAT IT MEANS TO HIS FILM CAREER.

■ By Malini Bhupta and Aditi Pai

On July 31, the day of his judgement, actor Sanjay Dutt took a leaf out of his film *Lage Raho Munnabhai* and decided to practise some Gandhigiri on Special TADA Judge Pramod Dattaram Kode. Soon after he was sentenced to six years in prison, Dutt rushed to the dock and pleaded: "Sir, I made a mistake 14 years ago, please grant me bail, I'd like to appeal. I am not mentally prepared for jail as I thought you will grant me probation."

As has always been the case with Bollywood's trouble child, Dutt's impulsive admission in court may cost him dear, since his counsel Satish Maneshinde has steadfastly denied all charges, including Dutt's confession. In response to Dutt's plea, Kode stated, "Sanjay, I have just done my duty. You know what you have done." Over 10 years, Kode has tracked not only the case, but also the actor closely, and in his ultimate analysis, he said: "Everyone makes mistakes, but the element of criminality in you is incurable."

With that, the matinee idol lost any hope he had harboured of walking away free. Says Maneshinde: "I had prepared him for this

"The element of criminality in you is incurable."

CHRONOLOGY OF BOMBAY BLAST CASE

MARCH 12, 1993 13 serial blasts rock the city of Mumbai

APRIL 13, 1993 Samir Hingora and Hanif Kadawala arrested, implicate Sanjay Dutt

APRIL 15, 1993 Dutt chargesheeted for possessing arms, arrested on April 19

NOVEMBER 4, 1993 10,000-page chargesheet filed against 189, including Dutt

NOVEMBER 19, 1993 Case handed over to the Central Bureau of Investigation